Who gets to hold the stopwatch?

A short while ago, the companies building the most powerful AI models began this whole doomsday narrative and put out a message asking the world to slow down frontier AI. Anthropic said that advances in model capability need to be paced so that safety work can catch up. OpenAI published a framework for reporting model misalignment, alongside six accounts of concerning behaviour. These warnings deserve attention. They also raise an awkward question: who gets to decide when it is safe to speed up again?

The concern is more than speculation. Reports describe AI agents acting beyond their instructions, concealing actions or behaving differently under evaluation. OpenAI has described an incident involving its agents and Hugging Face that prompted changes to its security and training. The details vary, and an incident under controlled conditions should not be mistaken for proof that every deployed model behaves the same. But increasingly capable systems can take consequential actions before a human catches a mistake. These concerns have been raised by industry experts ages ago. We've had reports of senior researchers leaving major AI companies after having been disillusioned with the work that's being done. Why slow down now?

A popular speculations is that the big companies are running out of money. There is this massive bubble being propped up by circular funding moving from chips companies to AI companies to data centre infrastructure companies. Each time the money is adding to the bubble, but it's the same money moving around, just that each time it moves, it's being counted again. Such bubbles have never been able to persist for too long. You have to slow down or deliver enough value that revenue starts flowing in to support the hype. So a slow down, before the bubble can burst and wreck the industry, seems reasonable.

AI companies have been doing away with the safety/alignment departments for a while.



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It's hard to believe that they've started taking AI safety seriously overnight. There's the talk about giving external experts access to examine models and their development. They are proposing third-party evaluators inside frontier labs, with employee level access.

But proximity brings its own problem. Reporting has raised questions about personal and professional ties within the small AI safety community. Such connections merit disclosure and examination. METR's founder worked at OpenAI at the same time as Anthropic's founder. Calling METR independent is a tall tale. They do not prove that an evaluator has softened a finding for a friend. Calling every researcher in that circle a company proxy would obscure the useful question: what can an evaluator do when its findings are inconvenient to the company?

A slowdown by the largest labs could give them time to improve safeguards. It could also leave their existing products, customers and computing advantages in place while new competitors face costly requirements. The rules must be examined for their effect on competition and their ability to reduce risk.

Independent oversight therefore needs a better definition than "a third party". Evaluators should disclose relevant relationships and funding, have meaningful access to systems and incident records, and be able to publish adverse conclusions and the limits of their investigation. Companies may have reasons to keep exploit details confidential. Confidentiality should not give them control over whether we learn of a serious failure. For technology proven to be this impactful, I don't believe there's any scope for confidentiality.

The decision to pause or restart a consequential system cannot rest with its developer or with an evaluator the developer can quietly dismiss. Public authorities will need the expertise and powers to examine the evidence, challenge conclusions and apply rules consistently across companies.